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The United States and the Gaza Ceasefire Resolution

The United Nations Security Council is responsible for maintaining international peace and security. It can pass resolutions that respond to international conflicts, impose sanctions, or call for ceasefires. However, the decisions made in the Council are often influenced by the political interests of powerful states, especially the permanent members who hold veto power.

During the Israel– Hamas war that began in 2023, the Security Council debated several resolutions related to the humanitarian crisis in Gaza. On February 20, 2024, the United States vetoed a resolution calling for an immediate humanitarian ceasefire. Although fourteen members of the Council supported the resolution, the U.S. veto prevented it from being adopted (United Nations).

This paper analyzes why the United States chose to veto this resolution. It uses two international relations theories, Realism and Liberalism to explain the same state behavior. The goal is to show how different theoretical perspectives can produce different explanations for the same decision. While realism focuses on power and strategic interests, liberalism emphasizes international institutions, diplomacy, and domestic political influences.

The conflict addressed in the resolution began in October 2023 when Hamas launched a large-scale attack on Israel. The attack resulted in civilian deaths and the capture of hostages. In response, Israel began a major military operation in Gaza aimed at destroying Hamas. As the conflict continued, the humanitarian situation in Gaza became increasingly severe. Many civilians were killed or injured, and infrastructure such as homes, hospitals, and schools was heavily damaged. International organizations raised concerns about shortages of food, water, and medical supplies. Because of these conditions, many countries called for an immediate ceasefire.

Members of the United Nations Security Council proposed a resolution demanding a humanitarian ceasefire and the protection of civilians. When the Council voted, fourteen members supported the resolution. However, the United States vetoed it, preventing it from passing. U.S. officials stated that the resolution did not adequately condemn Hamas or address the issue of hostages, and they argued that it could interfere with ongoing diplomatic negotiations (United States Mission to the UN).

Realism is one of the most influential theories in international relations. Realist scholars argue that the international system is anarchic, meaning there is no central authority that can enforce rules between states (Morgenthau 4). Because of this, states must prioritize their own security and national interests.

From a realist perspective, the U.S. veto can be explained by its strategic alliance with Israel. Israel has been one of the United States' closest allies for decades. The two countries cooperate closely on military and security issues. Realists would argue that the United States

wanted to support Israel during the conflict and prevent international pressure that could limit Israel's military actions (Morgenthau 181).

Realism also emphasizes the balance of power in the Middle East. The United States has long attempted to maintain influence in the region and counter the influence of rivals such as Iran. Weakening Hamas may align with these broader strategic goals. Another important factor is alliance credibility. If the United States failed to support Israel during a major conflict, other allies might question whether they could rely on U.S. support in the future. Supporting allies therefore reinforces the credibility of U.S. commitments.

Finally, realism highlights how powerful states use institutions like the Security Council to protect their interests. The veto power held by permanent members allows them to block resolutions that conflict with their strategic goals (Morgenthau 461).

Liberalism offers a different explanation for state behavior. Liberal theorists argue that international cooperation is possible through institutions, diplomacy, and economic interdependence (Keohane and Nye 19). Organizations like the United Nations provide opportunities for negotiation and conflict resolution.

From a liberal perspective, the U.S. veto may be seen as part of a diplomatic strategy. Instead of rejecting cooperation, the United States may have used the veto to influence negotiations about how the conflict should be addressed. Liberal theory also emphasizes the role of domestic politics. Leaders in democratic states must consider public opinion, political parties, and interest groups when making foreign policy decisions. Domestic debates in the United States about security, support for Israel, and humanitarian concerns may have

influenced the decision (Keohane and Nye 32). International institutions also serve as forums for discussion and diplomacy. Even though the resolution failed, the debate within the Security Council demonstrates how states use institutions to communicate their positions and attempt to shape international outcomes.

Realism and liberalism provide different explanations for the same event. Realism focuses on strategic interests, alliances, and power politics. According to this perspective, the United States vetoed the resolution to support Israel and maintain its influence in the Middle East. Liberalism focuses more on institutions, diplomacy, and domestic political factors. This perspective suggests that the veto may have been part of a broader diplomatic strategy aimed at influencing negotiations.

While both theories offer useful insights, realism provides the stronger explanation in this case. The long-standing alliance between the United States and Israel and the strategic importance of the Middle East suggest that geopolitical interests played a major role. However, liberalism still helps explain how the United States framed its decision in diplomatic terms and continued to participate in discussions within the Security Council.

This case raises questions about the effectiveness and legitimacy of the Security Council. One controversial feature of the Council is the veto power held by the five permanent members: the United States, China, Russia, France, and the United Kingdom. In this situation, the veto allowed one country to block a resolution that had the support of the rest of the Council. Critics argue that this weakens the legitimacy of the institution and limits its ability to respond to humanitarian crises (United Nations).

Realists would argue that this outcome reflects the reality of global power politics. The structure of the Security Council was designed to ensure that major powers would not be forced to accept decisions that go against their interests. Liberals, however, argue that institutions should promote cooperation and collective action. When veto power repeatedly blocks action, it can reduce the effectiveness of international institutions (Keohane and Nye 234).

I suggest reforms such as removing veto power from permanent members and expanding the Council's membership to improve representation. Without veto power, Security Council decisions could be made through majority voting, meaning that the resolution with the most votes would be adopted.

The United States veto of the Gaza ceasefire resolution demonstrates how international relations theories can explain state behavior in different ways. Realism emphasizes power, alliances, and strategic interests, suggesting that the United States acted to support Israel and maintain regional influence. Liberalism focuses on diplomacy, institutions, and domestic political factors. From this perspective, the veto may also reflect a broader diplomatic strategy within the United Nations. By applying both theories to the same case, this paper shows how different theoretical perspectives lead to different interpretations of state behavior in international politics.

Works Cited

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